Operations Analyst Exercise

Distinguished Scholar 10% Selection Process | March 31, 2023

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Purpose and questions for management

Distinguished Scholars are the students whose outstanding academic performance and contributions distinguish them from the broader program. To choose them fairly, we must determine which available measures should become the primary key performance indicators (KPIs) and which should be supporting qualifications. My first questions to a manager would be: What defines a Distinguished Scholar? What data are available? What is the main purpose of this recognition? Are there additional benefits expected from the analysis, especially for future admissions? What feedback exists on the current selection process?

Clarifying the project goal is important. Rather than treating the assignment as an isolated selection task, I would align the criteria with Correlation One's broader objective of understanding which fellows thrive in the program and what operational improvements may follow.

Data preparation and selection methodology

I took a quantitative, secondary-data approach because most of the supplied operational measures are numerical. The main KPI for selection was GPA. The accompanying Excel workbook preserves the original records in "exercise_data_raw" and works with a prepared view, "exercise_data_use"; "10%" is the GPA-sorted working sheet used to examine candidates, not a final selection until all eligibility rules are applied.

First, fellows needed a GPA of at least 3.5. Attendance then served as the primary qualifier: the 14 weekly attendance fields were evaluated as an overall rate, with at least 90% required. The raw data have blank attendance cells in K116:K152. I flagged these as N/A reporting discrepancies rather than automatically treating them as absences. This was an explicit fairness assumption about missing records, not confirmation that every affected fellow attended.

Extended Case grades and Review Module grades were then evaluated separately. Each needed an average of at least 80%, and any missing assignment submission disqualified the fellow from selection. Non-submissions were identified explicitly instead of being ignored by averaging formulas. This prevented high grades on a smaller number of submitted assignments from overstating academic performance.

Slack messages and reactions served as participation indicators, with modest engagement rather than high message volume prioritized. For a reproducible review of the written criteria, I applied a minimum of three messages and three reactions. My intention was to avoid disqualifying academically exceptional fellows merely for being quieter in the class community.

Selection results and student-level judgment

The cohort contains 618 students, so a 10% recognition target is 61.8, rounded to 62. Applying the above screening criteria to the workbook produces 73 qualifying fellows. The top 62 can then be chosen from that eligible group by descending GPA, with documented treatment of any ties. This distinction matters: simply taking the first 62 rows of the GPA-sorted “10%” tab would include fellows who do not satisfy all the rules.

Student ID 93 provides a useful example of why contextual judgment matters. This fellow was academically strong and reported very low programming proficiency, but relatively low Slack activity should not outweigh excellent attendance and academic performance when the engagement minimum has been met. Self-rated proficiency is a supporting observation, not proof of a student’s technical ability or motivation.

Exploratory insights and recommendations

To support future recruiting, I also analyzed sociodemographic characteristics in “analysis (so_demo)” alongside GPA. The population is concentrated in states such as California and New York, suggesting an opportunity to test outreach in states with smaller representation. This is a recruiting hypothesis rather than evidence that geography causes stronger performance.

Educational attainment is also worth examining. Fellows whose highest education was High School or GED performed competitively; future research could explore their results alongside age, experience, and admissions criteria before changing selection policies. Inclusive alumni testimonials could also broaden awareness of the program, with voluntary participation and respect for privacy, including LGBTQ+ representation.

For a production decision, I would request verified attendance corrections, a clear tie policy, and confirmation that the proposed academic and participation thresholds reflect program objectives. This selection process provides a repeatable starting point for recognizing scholars while informing future cohorts.